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FRIDAY, JANUARY 30, 2026

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CHICAGO POLICE DEPARTMENT

Homicide clearance rate hits 71%

Detective’s cold case breakthroughs, along with fewer city murders to solve, help buoy numbers

By Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

Two days after a 19-year-old woman was fatally shot through the window of a second-floor apartment in Washington Park,

a witness told a Chicago police detective, “This is gonna be taken care of anyways.”

And in fact the April 2, 2019, murder of Jiaerra Harris was the first of at least five intertwined shootings that involved a neigh-

borhood gang conflict, a deadly attempted carjacking downtown, a mass shooting at a subsequent memorial and the murders of two witnesses.

Records obtained by the Tribune detail how one of the Chicago Police Department’s most effective homicide investigators recently closed that 5-year-old cold case, helping to raise the department’s

murder clearance rate to its highest level in more than a decade.

CPD’s homicide clearance rate reached 71% last year — up from 55% in 2024 — amid a sharp decline in murders that helped buoy the figure. Records obtained by the Tribune show CPD detectives cleared fewer cases in 2025 — 296 — than in any year since 2019. That means detectives effec-

tively cleared cases among a smaller number of homicides, and continued to count the clearance of older cases in the department’s newest figure. In fact, of the cases cleared last year, records show more than 60% of them originated in years prior to 2025, the oldest being from 1987.

Turn to Clearance, Page 4

SONYA MASSEY MURDER



Donna Massey, left, mother of Sonya Massey, cries tears of joy as she stands with her sister-in-law, Tammy Massey, on Thursday after the sentencing of former Sangamon County Sheriff’s Deputy Sean Grayson at the Sangamon County Courthouse in Springfield. STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Ex-cop gets 20-year sentence

Family hails maximum penalty for downstate deputy who killed Black woman inside home

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Through sobs, Donna Massey told a packed Sangamon County courtroom on Thursday about the impact her daughter Sonya’s killing at the hands of a sheriff’s deputy had on her: short-term memory loss, inability to watch the news

and a fear of calling police as she worried she would meet the same fate as her daughter.

As Massey concluded her victim-impact statement, she turned toward her daughter’s killer, former Sangamon County Sheriff’s Deputy Sean Grayson, and spoke the same words Sonya Massey said to Grayson moments before the white deputy shot and

killed the Black mother of two. “I rebuke you in the name of Jesus,” Donna Massey sternly told Grayson from the witness stand.

Minutes later, Judge Ryan Cadagin sentenced Grayson to 20 years in prison for second-degree murder, the maximum penalty allowed under Illinois law and a rare, lengthy sentence for an on-duty police officer in the U.S. convicted of killing someone.

When the sentence was read, someone from the gallery shouted, “Yes!” and a woman’s

voice could be heard softly saying, “Thank you, thank you, God.”

Grayson, 31, will be required to serve at least half of his sentence — 10 years — under state law, though he has already received credit for 561 days spent in custody. A post-trial hearing is scheduled for March 6.

Sangamon County State’s Attorney John Milhiser recommended the 20-year sentence, telling the court during the hearing, “If the

Turn to Massey, Page 2

Shutdown averted as Democrats make deal

Budget package has window to negotiate restrictions on ICE

By Mary Clare Jalonick,
Kevin Freking and
Seung Min Kim
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Democrats and the White House have struck a deal to avert a partial government shutdown and temporarily fund the Department of Homeland Security as they negotiate new restrictions for President Donald Trump’s surge of immigration enforcement.

As the country reels from the deaths of two protesters at the hands of federal agents in Minneapolis, the two sides have agreed to separate the Homeland Security Department’s appropriation from the rest of the legislation and fund the agency for two weeks while they debate Democratic demands for curbs on the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agency. The potential deal comes after Democrats voted to block legislation to fund DHS on Thursday.

Trump said in a social media post that “Republicans and Democrats have come together to get the vast majority of the government funded until September,” while extending current funding for Homeland Security. He encouraged members of both parties to cast a “much needed Bipartisan ‘YES’ vote.”

Speaker Mike Johnson,

Turn to Deal, Page 10

Reader goes monthly under new owners with mission to revive alt-weekly heyday

By Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Reader, the groundbreaking alternative weekly which has been on the brink of dissolution for years, will become a monthly in February under new owners, who are looking to reinvent the storied newspaper while turning red ink to black.

Noisy Creek, a startup publisher on a mission to restore alternative weeklies to their offbeat journalistic glory, took over operations

at the Reader last fall, with plans to install a novel profit/nonprofit formula it has used since acquiring The Stranger in Seattle and the Portland Mercury in 2024.

“The vision is to bring an innovative business model to help support a trusted and beloved network of alt-weeklies around the country,” said Brady Walkinshaw, 41, a former Washington state representative and founder of Seattle-based Noisy Creek.

The Reader stopped the presses in December as part of a reboot that

involves everything from a new editor-in-chief to a revised publication schedule belying the alt-weekly category it helped create more than a half-century ago.

The blueprint involves scaling back to a monthly publication and implementing a hybrid business model where the Reader reverts to a for-profit newspaper, backed by philanthropic support. The Reader will also pursue alternative income streams to advertising, including a

Turn to Reader, Page 6



Editor-in-Chief Sarah Conway in the Chicago Reader office in Chicago’s Douglas neighborhood on Monday. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

